

Nothing Headphone 1

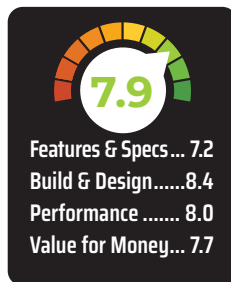
Visually daring, sonically reserved

The Nothing Headphone 1 isn't just a head-turner. It's surprisingly grown-up. With a transparent, cassette-like design for the earcups, tactile controls, and audio tuning by KEF, it aims to offer a more refined listening experience. But does this debut deliver more than just transparent aesthetic appeal?

DESIGN AND COMFORT

True to the brand's identity, the design of the Nothing Headphone 1 is unmistakably bold and distinct. The transparent elements and visible internals make a statement, and in the hand, the design is even more impressive. The overall profile breaks away from the standard dome-shaped design that has become a standard for over-ear headphones. Most major players, from Sony to Sennheiser, follow this dome aesthetic. Sure, there are exceptions like the V-Moda Crossfade, but Nothing has deliberately veered off the conventional path. The headband and earcups resemble a stylised cassette tape, giving it a nostalgic yet futuristic appeal. But while the visual design is striking, the real question is whether these choices were made for function or simply for flair.

In terms of build, the headphone feels solid thanks to the combination of aluminium and high-quality plastic. It isn't luxury-tier, but it doesn't feel cheap either. It weighs 329 grams which is lighter than the AirPods Max. The memory foam padding is comfortable for short to moderate listening sessions, and the sliding telescopic arms adjust smoothly to different head sizes. However, in a temperature-controlled room, wearing the headphones for an hour resulted in noticeable sweat buildup around the ears. The PU cushions



are soft to touch and feel premium, but they do trap heat, which may affect long-term comfort, especially in warmer environments. These are also not user-replaceable, and in case of wear and tear, you will have to visit the service centre to get them changed.

I found the clamping force good, they isolate the ambient sounds quite well, but after about an hour or so, I did start noticing some fatigue. Not painful, just enough to remind you they exist. They're not as cloud-like as the Bose QC series or the XM5s, but your neck won't feel bogged down either. They're IP52-rated, went through 50 durability tests, and feel like they could survive both your bag and your bad moods.

The Nothing Headphone 1 is IP52-rated for protection from dust ingress and splashes of water and come with a fold-flat hard case that's made from felt

material. It looks cool and feels nice but one area of improvement I feel is the case's zipper quality which feels subpar compared to the rest of the product.

CONTROLS AND APP EXPERIENCE

Unlike many modern headphones that rely on touch gestures, Nothing takes a different approach for the Headphone 1. There are four physical controls on the right earcup: a roller for volume and media control, a paddle for track skipping and scrubbing, a customisable multifunction button, and a power switch toggle. Everything's tactile, and feels very analogue in a good way. There's a 3.5 mm audio out as well, and you can even use the USB-C cable to playback tracks in AAC/SBC codec, since LDAC is only supported over wireless.

Nothing also lets you customise all of it in the app, which, thankfully, is as clean as their hardware. You can remap buttons, toggle ANC modes, enable head tracking, and most importantly, access an advanced 8-band parametric EQ that even allows entering specific frequencies. The EQ is responsive and precise, adding real value for users who want to fine-tune their sound.

AUDIO PERFORMANCE

The Nothing Headphone 1 features 40mm dynamic drivers tuned in collaboration with KEF, a respected name with over six decades of expertise in high-fidelity sound. It is a mature, well-balanced sound signature that performs consistently well across all genres.

In detailed listening tests using a barrage of reference tracks, not just the usual suspects, but also the kind of layered, genre-jumping music that tests audio separation, spatial accuracy, and tonal balance, the headphones performed impressively.

Out of the box, the Headphone 1 offers a Balanced tuning that leans slightly warm without losing clarity. Tracks like Boom by Tiësto and The Plan by Travis Scott showcase tight, controlled bass with enough weight to feel engaging, though it avoids the deep,